Essay Questions

Career Progression and Rationale

1. **Provide a summary of your career since graduating from university, explaining the rationale behind your key decisions and career progression. Include a description of your current (or most recent) role, covering the scope of your work, major responsibilities, employees under your supervision, budget size, clients/products, and any notable results achieved. (500 words maximum)**

Last year, I was admitted to a design-engineering programme at NUS, but I turned it down. It was the first time I had walked away from something I had worked hard to get.

In 2023, I joined Wells Fargo full-time after two internships. I started as a frontend engineer, building screens for trading clients in an eight-member team across India and the US. I wanted to understand the application beyond those screens, so I asked for backend work and learnt it myself. I built services that process and store trading data, and scheduled jobs that send files to other systems. I understood the system but not why we were building it.

When the tech lead handling test automation for my line of business was preparing to leave, I asked to take over testing for my projects. Having built these applications, I could identify which test cases mattered most. I achieved 100% functional test automation across four applications. I became the subject-matter expert for test automation, and my manager referred other teams to me for guidance. The US-based Line of Business head recommended my approach as a standard for other teams.

Last year I took on application migrations early to experiment with AI and agentic workflows. I led the migration of three applications within the Valuations portal from an older framework to Java, covering seven business workflows in three months, using GitHub Copilot to generate about 40% of the code. The initiative became a highlight for our India team, with US leadership flying in for our presentations. I was trusted with how we migrated, but which applications to migrate was still decided above me.

Since my promotion to Senior Software Engineer in January 2026, I own delivery and production stability across the Valuations portal and am the primary frontend developer for a trading-vendor platform. I coordinate with over 25 stakeholders across business, vendor and technology teams to refine requirements and align releases. I automated pricing report

distribution to over 125 clients and created UI mockups to help stakeholders visualise new features on the platform, which has onboarded over 100 Front and Middle Office companies. I have no formal direct reports or budget ownership, but I work across teams to keep deliverables on track. My contributions have been recognised through Spotlight Awards presented by my manager. I now sit in discussions where features are decided, but the decisions are not mine to make.

I thought design would bring me closer to those decisions. I completed the Google UX Design Professional Certificate, built a portfolio and was admitted to NUS for its 2026 intake. Speaking to students, I saw that most graduates stayed in design roles. I realised I didn't want to own just the design of a product; I wanted to own the product itself, from identifying what to build and why to bring it to market. That is what Katha, the brand I want to build, will need from me. So I turned NUS down, and chose an MBA instead.

2. **Describe your short and long-term career aspirations, including your target geography, industry, and function. How do you plan to bridge the gap between your current position and these goals, and how will INSEAD help you achieve them? (300 words maximum)**

My father had always been the one who provided for our family. After he died of cancer three years ago, my mother organised our finances and began teaching mathematics. She listed two rooms on Airbnb. I managed pricing and guest messages while she handled hosting. Within three months, we became Superhosts.

Many women never get a chance. Once patronised by the Begums of Bhopal (my home-town) as a livelihood, zardozi embroidery still supports artisan communities, yet reaching wider markets remains difficult. My long term vision is to build Katha, a fashion brand that brings the weavers' craft to international customers through contemporary designs, so the women behind each piece earns a lasting income from it.

At Wells Fargo, I have progressed from building screens to owning applications end to end. I can build Katha's storefront and artisan tools, but need to develop commercial and product strategy skills. After INSEAD, I aim to become a product manager at a European fashion e-commerce platform such as Zalando, learning how seller tools serve brands and buyers before launching Katha.

At INSEAD, Strategic Pricing and Value Creation in Luxury and Fashion would help me understand how brands create value. The Retail, Consumer and Luxury Goods Club would connect me with the industry through events like Paris Fashion Week networking cocktail. I would use the INSEAD Venture Competition to pressure-test Katha's model with judges and investors. My conversation with Amnah Ahmad(MBA'26J), who spent five years as a software

engineer before pursuing Product Management, gave me a more grounded picture of the transition ahead. Her experience of navigating a three-way pivot across roles, industry and geography resonated with me. Her stories of alumni readily offering support and classmates camping together in the Philippines showed me the sense of community that extends beyond the classroom.

3. **Give a candid description of yourself as a person and a leader, emphasizing the strengths and weaknesses you recognize in yourself. Explain how you are actively working on your development, sharing key experiences that have shaped you, providing specific examples where relevant. (500 words maximum)**

“I didn’t know you had this side to you,” my teacher said after I added a humorous twist to my story at a story-weaving competition. Until then, I had been the girl bullied for being quiet, finding comfort in studies. Four friends encouraged me to step outside that comfort zone. We prepared for Annual Day, staying back to practice dances and skits. Gradually, I began participating on my own. I hadn’t known that side of me either. Once I found it, I started looking for what else I had been holding back.

That search carried into my career. At Wells Fargo, I asked my manager how to improve my chances of promotion. Her answer was simple: ownership. Until then, I completed assigned responsibilities and considered my job done. I began taking on work no one else owned, expanding my test automation role across projects. Colleagues approached me for guidance, and I took pride in becoming someone others could rely on. It also fed my need to prove myself.

When I tried moving into product-focused companies such as Amazon and Google, I struggled to get callbacks. Instead of exploring other options, I stopped applying. I began questioning my abilities, as though falling short meant I wasn’t good enough. I had tied my self-worth to performance more than I realized.

After my father passed away, I buried my grief in work, taking on more than I could sustain. Therapy helped me recognize these patterns and the imposter syndrome behind them. I began acknowledging small wins instead of immediately moving to the next goal, and recognizing qualities I valued beyond professional achievements. Journaling helped me appreciate my progress without measuring it against what I had yet to accomplish.

Helping run an Airbnb with my mother exposed me to people navigating different career paths and setbacks. One guest shared how a disappointing score led him to set aside his MBA plans and build his own venture. Today, he runs an established startup and travels to explore expansion opportunities. His journey showed me that a setback can be a reason to reconsider one's path, not give up on one's ambitions.

At Drzya Shakti, the entrepreneurs I met challenged my perspective. Javed Ahmed, who has a locomotor disability, works to preserve Jammu and Kashmir's cultural heritage. His work has earned honours including the Swarnim Award and Helen Keller Award. Seeing how he channeled his circumstances into something meaningful made me reflect on my tendency to dwell on difficulties. His story helped me process my grief, reminding me that difficult experiences need not prevent us from finding purpose.

I have come a long way from the person who hesitated to put herself out there, but I am still learning to accept uncertainty and imperfection. I sometimes take on more than I can manage and struggle when things don't go as planned. I am learning to recognize my worth beyond achievements, ask for help and see setbacks as part of growth rather than reflections of my abilities.

4. Describe a highly stressful situation you faced and how you managed it. What did this experience teach you about yourself and your interactions with others? (400 words maximum)

It started with a fridge magnet from Bali. Ishi was packing to leave for her MBA, and as I reached to take it down, I stopped. We bought it on our first trip together. Polaroids from three years of living together covered our walls, each holding a memory of a life we had built together.

Ishi had become my closest friend in Bengaluru, and after my father passed away, she was the person I leaned on most. I was happy for her, but I hadn't anticipated her leaving to hit me so hard. I couldn't bring myself to look for a new flat. I asked my manager if I could work remotely, went home to my mother, and cried for days without understanding why.

It felt as though everyone I loved was leaving, and everything I had grown attached to was coming to an end. While I was happy for my friend, I felt stranded as everything familiar seemed to be changing at once. I eventually sought therapy, where I began to connect my reaction to the grief of losing my father three years earlier, which I had never fully processed. My therapist also encouraged me to join a journaling group where strangers shared their daily experiences and struggles. At first, I only listened. One day, I spoke about a small setback at work. No one treated me as a burden; others shared similar moments of their own. I also started attending art workshops, where working on something side by side made it easier to talk to people I didn't know, and those conversations slowly grew beyond small talk.

This experience helped me recognise how much I had relied on a small, familiar circle for a sense of belonging. I learnt that opening up about my struggles does not make me a burden; vulnerability can help people connect and understand one another more deeply. Meaningful connections don't always have to begin with an existing bond; they can grow when we are willing to share a little of ourselves. I'm now more comfortable reaching out, listening to others and allowing new relationships to develop at their own pace. Most importantly, I learnt that while people and circumstances change, I can build connections and find a sense of belonging in new places.

5. Is there anything else that was not covered in your application that you would like to share with the Admissions Committee? (maximum 300 words)

I knew when a wedding was coming up, it meant a trip to my aunt's studio with my mother to pick up an outfit. I admired the colorful fabrics and intricate zardozi embroidery, often more excited about what I would wear than the occasion itself. My aunt worked with women from the local Muslim community who brought these designs to life through delicate needlework. I loved wearing those dresses to family events and the compliments that followed.

In tenth grade, I bought my first pair of baggy jeans covered in stickers. Until then, my mother had mostly picked my clothes. That choice sparked my interest in experimenting with fashion and expressing myself. Moving to Bengaluru and earning my own money gave me the freedom to build my wardrobe. I enjoyed experimenting with styles, from cosplaying as my favourite character for Halloween to coordinating outfits for a friend's bachelorette.

Over time, I began questioning my approach. Learning about fast fashion exposed me to its environmental impact and worker exploitation. I appreciated the skill and stories behind traditional crafts. Rather than constantly buying clothes, I restyled familiar pieces through layering and accessories. I taught myself to crochet through YouTube, creating pieces for my outfits. I also shared Pinterest looks, styling tips and affiliate links to help others recreate them.

Manish Malhotra's MAA collection at Paris Haute Couture Week caught my attention. Its sculptural mother-and-child figures at different life stages turned a personal relationship into a story told through clothing, bringing Indian craftsmanship to a global stage.

At INSEAD, I want to bring an Indian perspective to the Retail, Consumer and Luxury Goods Club's conversations on fashion and craftsmanship. Long term, I want to build a brand reimagining Indian heritage for global audiences while creating visibility and economic opportunities for local women artisans.

6.A. Please list significant extracurricular/extra-professional activities in which you are/have been involved, starting with your most recent activities (i.e. sports, performing arts, associations, club memberships, hobbies, community activities, etc.)

Maximum 5 entries

B. Describe the activities you listed above and explain how they have enriched your life (e.g., skills developed, personal growth, community impact). (300 words maximum)

Outside work, I keep returning to the same problem: people with something to offer, and no easy way for it to reach others.

As Projects Head at VIT's IEEE Computer Society, I helped develop Chota Dhobi after seeing how mismanaged laundry frustrated students across our hostels. We wanted to make the process easier not just for students, but also for the laundry workers handling these requests. The app grew to 50,000 users. It taught me to design for the people behind a service as well as the people using it.

As an Executive Board Member at Girl Up Vellore, I worked on initiatives around women in STEM, menstrual health, mental health and LGBTQ+ inclusion. When our first mental health initiative saw limited participation, we explored poetry, photography and art as alternative forms of expression. I realised that not everyone opens up in the same way, and sometimes, creating space for people means finding different ways to reach them.

At Drzya Shakti Trust, I work with students with disabilities to transform their artwork into marketable products, including eco-friendly flags and festive embellishments, which get sold at exhibitions so the students earn from their work. I guide them, and keep the ideas theirs. I also designed a calendar and brochure featuring 12 entrepreneurs with disabilities from across India and secured three corporate sponsors. Learning about their ventures made me think about how many remarkable people we never discover, simply because their work hasn’t reached a wider audience.

At INSEAD, I hope to explore the intersections of creativity, business and social impact through the Women in Business and INDEVOR.

7. Please list your most significant examples of international exposure that you have experienced living, studying, working or travelling outside your own country (Region)

Maximum 6 entries

Thailand | June 2024 | Family Leisure Trip

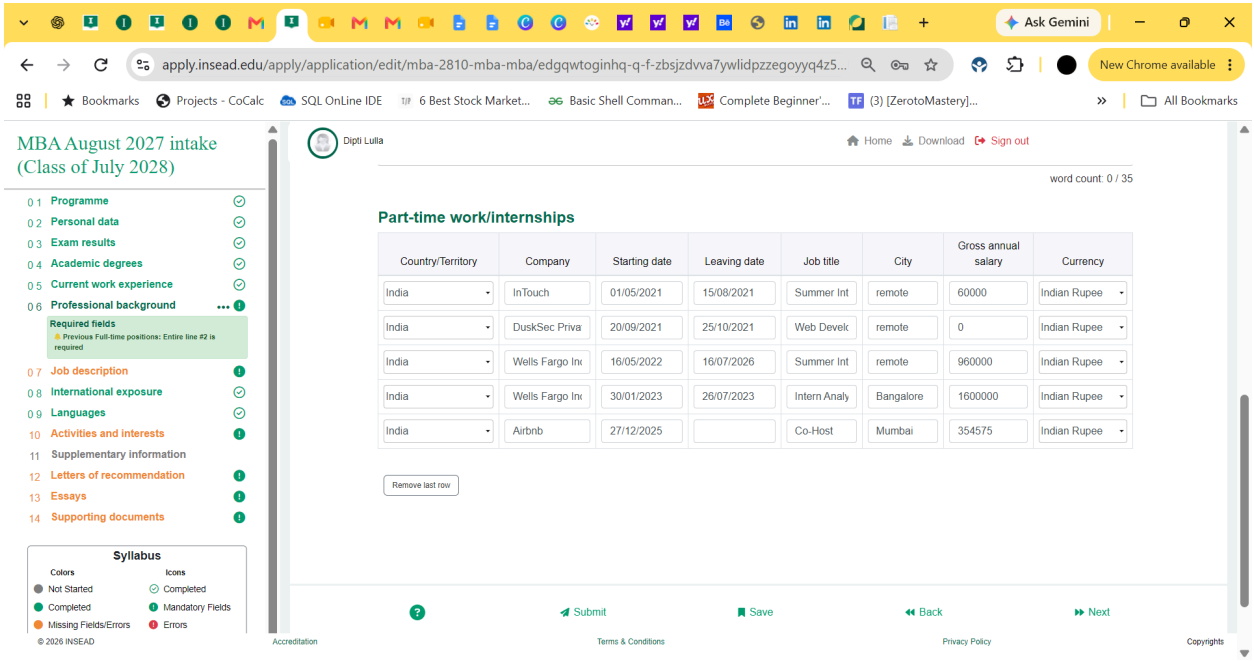
I took the lead in planning a family trip to Thailand, coordinating bookings and activities to create a memorable holiday together. In Phuket, witnessing vibrant Pride celebrations, with people of all ages participating, exposed me to a public celebration of diversity that I had not personally experienced before. At Safari World in Bangkok, I was delighted when Bollywood songs played during a show's intermission, prompting Indian visitors to dance enthusiastically while visitors from other countries joined in when music from their cultures played. This spontaneous celebration of cultural identity made me appreciate how shared experiences can bring people from diverse backgrounds together. Exploring Bangkok's temples, the Erawan Museum and a traditional floating market introduced me to Thailand's architectural heritage and culinary traditions. Discovering Hindu deities such as Ganesha in Thai religious spaces also prompted me to reflect on the cultural connections between India and Southeast Asia.

Bali, Indonesia | June 2025 | Leisure Travel with Friends

My first international trip with two flatmates, Bali was an opportunity to explore a new culture together after months of planning. We travelled across Ubud, Seminyak, Canggu and Uluwatu, experiencing Bali's diverse landscapes and local traditions. In Ubud, I was struck by how nature was woven into everyday experiences, from rice-terrace surroundings to forests where monkeys roamed freely. I was also fascinated by the parallels between Balinese and Indian Hindu traditions, while noticing how shared deities and beliefs took distinct cultural forms. A traditional matcha preparation ceremony and exploring Bali's natural landscapes further broadened my exposure to unfamiliar customs and ways of life.

Mini Application Questions

1. **Campus Preference:** Fontainebleau
2. **Academic Distinction:** N/A
3. **Number of staff directly reporting to you and Total staff under your responsibility:** 0
4. **Sponsorship**
5. **Explain any gaps of two months or more in your employment history from the time you left high school to the start of the MBA programme. Include details on how you have spent, or plan to spend, that time. (35 words maximum)**
6. **Add Details of Part-time Work/ Internships**



7. **Language Declaration**
   English fluent, Hindi native
8. **Awards: List any distinctions, honours and awards achieved through your extracurricular activities.**

Activity	From	To	Position / Level
Science	31/12/2021	16/02/2023	Leadership position
Ethics	24/05/2021	01/11/2021	Leadership position
Volunteering, Humanitarian	26/09/2026	29/10/2026	Club/Association membership
Painting	—	—	Intermediate
Knitting/Sewing	—	—	Intermediate

9. **Which other school(s) have you applied to?**

Country/Territory	Institution
India	ISB – Indian School of Business, Hyderabad
United Kingdom	London Business School
France	HEC Paris

10. Additional Letters?